



COASTING TO GLORY

Ivory Coast overcame Nigeria in a **pulsating final** to win the Africa Cup of Nations (AFCON) 2023.

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Anation actively recruiting players through a social networking site. A Premier League shot-stopper benched in favour of his cousin who plays in the French third division. All eight quarterfinalists from the previous edition, failing to do so this time out. These are just some of the quips that the Africa Cup of Nations (AFCON) 2023 phenomenon had in store for football fans.

The competition might be the nemesis of top European leagues (ask Jurgen Klopp) — with teams missing out on key players during the intense period of fixtures in January. **But, when it comes to on-field unpredictability and entertainment, no other competition comes close to the African Cup of Nations.**

Host Ivory Coast's journey to the title was nothing short of a movie screenplay. The Elephants looked to be heading out after a humiliating 4-0 loss to Equatorial Guinea in its final group-stage encounter. It even went to the extent of sacking manager Jean-Louis Gasset after the loss before sneaking into the playoff rounds as the fourth-best third-placed team.

The knockout rounds also had plenty of drama in store. The team came back from a goal down to force extra time before edging powerhouse Senegal through penalties in the round of 16.

The difficulty level rose a notch in the quarterfinal against Mali after defender Odilon Kossounou was sent off in the 43rd minute. Ivory Coast's fate looked to be sealed when Nene Dorgeles put Mali in front. But a 90th-minute equaliser followed by an added-time winner at the end of 120 minutes sealed a comeback for the ages.

The script then set up a fitting climax in the final against Nigeria as Franck Kessie and cancer survivor Sebastian Haller scored two goals in the last half-hour to complete yet another comeback and help the nation to its third African Cup of Nations trophy.

"It is more than a fairytale. I am